

TWO-IN-ONE MOBILE

Consumers can now use one cellphone with two SIM cards working simultaneously

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The ability to operate two SIM (subscriber identity modules) cards in a single mobile phone is now available with the consumers. Carrying two phones at the same time for business and personal calls is no longer required as users can now use the same cellphone to send and receive calls from two numbers simultaneously.

The technology

Dual SIM card technology had hit the market some years ago but gained popularity recently. "A dual SIM phone uses two networks for data transmission. It can use GSM and CDMA or GSM and GSM," informs Naved Choudhary, head-marketing, Intex Technologies.

While normal GSM phones contain a single transceiver, dual SIM phones have dual transceivers and display signal strength for both the networks.

When dual SIM technology was first introduced some years ago, users could insert two SIM cards in a single phone. However, both the cards could not be made active simultaneously, and users had to switch off the phone while switching between two cards. To overcome this difficulty, manufacturers upgraded the technology that allowed users to switch between cards without turning the phone off.

However, this technology also did not address the main difficulty, and only one SIM card could be used at a time. "If users were expecting calls from both the lines, they had to choose which SIM to keep active. With this technology, users could receive calls from one SIM card while the other was kept inactive," explains Prem Kumar, CEO, FLY Mobile.

Recently, mobile phone manufacturers have addressed this drawback

as well by releasing models that allow continuous use of two SIM cards simultaneously. With this, users can choose which number incoming callers can use and which number to use for outgoing calls. Now no more switching between SIM cards is necessary and users have the freedom to manage two separate phone lines without the hassle of carrying two handsets.

New models

With the demand for dual SIM phones growing, major handset brands like Fly Mobile, Samsung, Intex, Motorola are offering new models in this segment.

"Almost 60 per cent of Intex mobile phones use dual SIM card technology. The latest in this series are IN 4477 and IN 2020 Elegant," says Choudhary.

Fly Mobile is also set to announce a mega launch of nine new dual SIM handsets. "The collection includes DS 210, a slider phone with 3.2 megapixel camera, MP3 and MP4 players. DS 180 is a bar phone which is pocket-friendly with 2 megapixel camera, torchlight, FM and MP3 player. These phones are affordable and the price ranges from Rs 1900 to Rs 7990," informs Kumar.

Recently, Motorola and Samsung have also introduced phones with dual SIM cards. Motorola MING A1800 model can work with two SIMs simultaneously and supports two networks—CDMA and GSM. Samsung B5702 dual-standby mobile phone supports quad-band connectivity. The phone features two LED lights to help differentiate between the two SIM cards.

Reasons to go for it

The dual SIM card technology is not only useful for those who keep a line dedicated for business calls but also quite handy for those who travel fre-

quently. Rather than paying roaming charges or switching phones when crossing international borders, travellers can insert dual SIM cards of two countries into their mobile phones and switch between them. This saves them a lot of time, difficulty and pocket space.

According to Kumar, "The business and personal numbers operate independently. There are some value-added service features as well like international roaming facility, giving users the freedom to make personal calls from a business number. When network coverage is poor, switching over to another network provider is also available."

It is also beneficial for people who travel in India and can use local SIM cards to avoid huge roaming charges. They can take advantage of any service provider. For example, a user may use Airtel for making cheap STD calls but Reliance for making local calls.

While there are many advantages of this technology, the only drawback that is being faced by the consumers is the large and bulky appearance of the phones with dual SIM cards. They also have a shorter battery life.

Bright future ahead

Mobile phone brands are upbeat about this technology and see a good potential market for cellphones with this technology. "This technology has a bright future. As per latest industry reports, India is adding more than 10 million new mobile phone users every month. Also, considering the increasing demand for dual SIM card phones, this technology is here to stay," says Choudhary. Kumar also agrees that dual SIM card market will grow as more and more users will start using dual SIM phones because of the convenience and affordability factors. ●